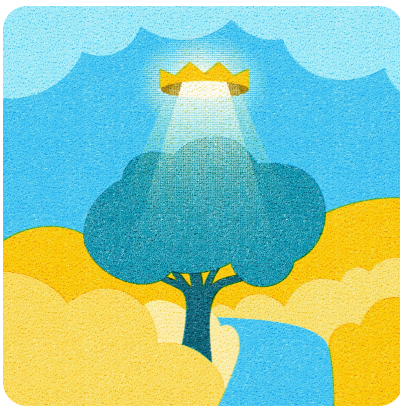




## Class Notes

# Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature

Psalms 1-2

Dr. Tim Mackie

What does it mean to read the Bible as meditation literature? Learn the tools and skills that unlock the Bible's literary styles—structure, parallelism, and repeated words—and see how Psalms 1 and 2 invite a lifetime of engagement with Scripture.

Last updated on: August 5, 2026

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# Module 1: Biblical Meditation

## SESSIONS 1-4

How does the Bible talk about reading the Bible? Learn about the biblical portrayal of Scripture meditation.

# Session 1: What Is Meditation Literature?

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## Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible instructs people to *hagah* (“meditate”) on God’s words. That involves a lifelong, thoughtful, embodied, repetitive, and ongoing practice that leads to the formation of the whole person in the shape of the object of meditation.
- The Jewish communities around the time of Jesus understood their Scriptures to be meditation literature.
- The description “meditation literature” speaks not only to the content of the Bible, but also its form. The subject matter of Scripture, God’s words and deeds, is worthy of our meditation. Its form is designed for engagement through re-readings over a lifetime.

## How to Read the Bible as Meditation Literature

One of the main ways we talk about the Bible in our BibleProject resources is, “The Bible is a collection of ancient Jewish meditation literature.”

What do we mean by “meditation”? The term comes from a handful of biblical passages that refer to the ideal reader of the scriptural collection of scrolls.

### **Psalms 1:1-2 LEB\***

How good is life for the man who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked;  
nor does he stand in the way of sinners;  
nor does he sit in the assembly of mockers.  
Instead, **in the instruction** (literally, *torah*) **of Yahweh** is his delight,  
And **on his instruction** (literally, *torah*) **he meditates** day and night.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Joshua 1:7-8 LEB\***

Only be strong and very courageous to observe diligently the whole *torah* that Moses my servant commanded you.  
Do not turn aside from it, to the right or left,  
so that you may succeed wherever you go.  
**The scroll of this torah** will not depart from your mouth;  
you will **meditate on it** day and night  
so that you may observe diligently all that is written in it.  
For then you will succeed in your ways and prosper.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher



Here Joshua and “the man” of Psalm 1 are portrayed as ideal figures. Their way of life is described in terms of moral integrity (Ps. 1:1) and faithfulness to the terms of God’s covenant with Israel (Josh. 1:7). The source of this divine direction is “the *torah* of Yahweh” (Ps. 1:2) and “the *torah* of Moses” (Josh. 1:7). These written texts are the focus of their meditation.

## English: Meditate, Hebrew: *Hagah* (הגה)

We know that later Jewish Bible nerds took this to heart. For example, the Dead Sea Scroll community (a group of exiled priests in the desert of Judea) described their most learned scripture scholars in relation to *hagah*: “... those educated in the scroll of meditation (ספר הגי) and in the principles of the covenant ...” (Damascus Document 10.6), “... the priests who are educated in the scroll of meditation (ספר הגי) ...” (Damascus Document 13.2).

This word, *hagah*, is fascinating. A survey of its 25 occurrences in the Hebrew Bible reveals that it differs from our contemporary conceptions of meditation.

*Hagah* is used for quiet, low-volume sounds from an animal’s mouth.

### Isaiah 38:14 NIV\*

I cried like a swift or thrush,  
I ***hagah*** like a mourning dove.  
My eyes grew weak as I looked to the heavens.  
I am being threatened; Lord, come to my aid!

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Isaiah 59:11 NASB\*

All of us growl like bears,  
and ***hagah*** sadly like doves;  
we hope for justice, but there is none,  
for salvation, but it is far from us.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Isaiah 31:4 NIV\*

... a lion, even a great lion ***hagah*** over its prey—  
and though a whole band of shepherds is called together against it,  
it is not frightened by their shouts or disturbed by their clamor

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

*Hagah* is used for quiet speech of a human, for secrecy.

### Psalms 38:12 LEB\*

Those who seek my life lay snares as well,  
and those intent on my harm speak threats.  
They also ***hagah*** treachery all day.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Proverbs 24:1-2 NASB\***

Do not be envious of evil men,  
nor desire to be with them;  
for their hearts **hagah** violence,  
and their lips talk of trouble.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

*Hagah* can be used positively, as a means of focusing one's thoughts on God, but verbally and audibly.

**Psalms 63:6 NIV\***

On my bed I remember you;  
I **hagah** about you through the watches of the night.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Psalms 77:11-12 NIV\***

I will remember the deeds of the Lord;  
yes, I will remember your miracles of long ago.  
I will **hagah** all your works  
and ponder all your mighty deeds.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Psalms 35:28 NIV\***

My tongue will **hagah** your righteousness,  
your praises all day long.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

*Hagah* describes the act of "uttering" but presupposes that what a person utters has been an object of their focus.

**Psalms 37:30-31 NIV\***

The mouths of the righteous **hagah** wisdom,  
and their tongues speak what is just.  
The law of their God is in their hearts;  
their feet do not slip.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Job 27:3-4 NIV\***

as long as I have life within me,  
the breath of God in my nostrils,  
my lips will not say anything wicked,  
and my tongue will not **hagah** lies.

## Reflections on What It Means to *Hagah* on Scripture

In Psalm 1 and Joshua 1, to *hagah* on a scroll involves focusing one's mind on a set of texts by reading them out loud at a low volume.

*Hagah* is a multisensory act, engaging not just the mind, but also one's body (the mouth, throat, vocal chords). *Hagah* involves consistency and repetition ("day and night"), as well as recitation, oral performance, and mental focus.

Apparently, the Scriptures are the kinds of texts that a person can *hagah* day and night over the course of an entire lifetime. This implies that the subject matter of Scripture (what the Bible is about) is worth meditating on. Perhaps it is also a demand made on the reader by Scripture's mode of communication and literary style.

To take these reflections further, let us consider a poem from a very different time and place: France in the 1960s!

## An Example of Modern Meditation Literature: OuLiPo



Motte, Warren (2015). *Oulipo: A Primer on Potential Literature*. Dalkey Archive Press. 25.



Archives Pontigny-Cerisy (2017). [TheParisReview.org](http://TheParisReview.org).

OuLiPo: *Ouvroir de littérature potentielle*; roughly translated, “workshop of potential literature.” Oulipo was a collective of mostly French mathematicians, linguists, and philosophers who began meeting in the 1960s to produce a diverse range of literary works, including stories, poetry, and essays. They used less-than-common constraints to bend our perceptions of what constitutes “literature.”

For instance, in 1961, Jean Lescure developed the S+7 method where every noun chosen is replaced by the seventh noun found after it in the dictionary. Georges Perec wrote *A Void* in 1969, a novel using only words that do not have the letter “e.” Prior to cofounding Oulipo, Raymond Queneau wrote “Exercises in Style” (1947). He retold one short story 99 times, each time in a different literary style (e.g., anagrams, sentences with four words, free verse, haiku, entirely passive verbs, etc.).

The “Liminal Poem,” seen above, is written as a chiasm with each word increasing the number of letters to the middle, then decreasing until the end. The reader can engage the poem on multiple levels, mentally, aurally, and visually. To fully experience it, one has to *hagah*: read and re-read out loud, focusing one’s attention on not just what the poem is about, but also how it communicates.

This “how” piece of literature is called a “poetics of literature.” “Poetics” is from the Greek *poiesis*, meaning craftsmanship, or style of work. “Literature” is intentionally crafted communication in which artistic form is crucial to understanding the content. A poetics of literature refers to understanding the unique artistic style and literary conventions used by an author to convey their message.

Authors produce every work of literature within a cultural context, where practices, conventions, and constraints specific to that time and place shape the authors. The Oulipo group is an excellent example of a highly contextualized community of authors who produced literature that was recognizable to those outside their circle, but also unique and peculiar to their group. That uniqueness means that Oulipo literature makes unique demands upon the reader and requires an adjustment of expectations in order to engage it on a deeper level.

Becoming a wiser, more informed reader of biblical texts means acknowledging that the biblical authors (i.e., ancient Israelite scribes) were part of a culturally specific tradition of literature. Ancient Israelite scribes operated over a long period of time. Their cultural practices and assumptions about how to compose, preserve, and pass on their literary traditions shaped them.

What were those constraints and conventions? What scribal instincts did the Israelites share with their Egyptian, Canaanite, and Mesopotamian counterparts? Which instincts did scribes adapt within the Israelite context? What do they take for granted in their communication style that readers outside their circle have to adopt consciously?

# Biblical Oulipo: The Poetics of Composition in the Hebrew Bible and Jewish Literature

Here are a few easily identifiable constraints, conventions, and literary strategies used by the biblical authors.

## Fun with the Alphabet

Some biblical authors use alphabet poems, such as acrostics. Lamentations consists of five alphabetic poems. Poems 1, 2, and 3 are 66 lines each, three lines for each sequential letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Poem 4 is 44 lines, two lines for each letter of the alphabet. Poem 5 is 22 lines, one line for each letter in the alphabet, but changing things up. Each line does not begin with the letters of the alphabet.

In [Psalms 111](#) and [112](#), each poetic line begins with the following letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Similarly, in [Psalms 25](#) and [34](#), each poetic line starts with the next letter of the alphabet. However, both poems have an additional line at the end, beginning with the same word, “redeem” (Hebrew: *padah* / פָּדָה). This creates an odd number of 23 lines in each poem.

The first letter of the Hebrew alphabet is ‘aleph (א). The middle of the alphabet is lamed (ל). The last letter is peh (פ). When you put them all together in Hebrew, you get the word ‘aleph (אלף). In Aramaic, this is the word for “learn,” making it a multi-language pun.

Atbash is a literary device in which the normal sequence of the alphabet is reversed, so that every letter chosen for a word is replaced by its matching opposite on the other side of the alphabet.

|         |   |   |   |     |   |   |   |
|---------|---|---|---|-----|---|---|---|
| English | A | B | C | ... | X | Y | Z |
|         | Z | Y | X | ... | C | B | A |
| Hebrew  | א | ב | ג | ... | ך | ש | ת |
|         | ת | ש | ך | ... | ג | ב | א |

*Atbash Example.* Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

Here are some forms of atbash used in the Hebrew Bible.

- [Jeremiah 25:26](#) “the king of Sheshakh” (ששך) = Babel (בבל), “Babylon”!

- [Jeremiah 51:41](#) “How Sheshakh (ששך) has been captured!”
- [Jeremiah 51:1](#) “I am going to arouse a destroying wind against Babylon and against the inhabitants of *lev qamai*” (לְבִיקְמַי) = *khasdim* (כַּשְׁדִּים), “Chaldeans”

## Numerical Symbolism

The use of the number seven in the creation narrative is an example of how the biblical authors used numerical symbolism. The Hebrew words “seven” and “complete, fulfilled” are spelled with the same letters (they are homonyms): שבע. The authors structured the seven-day creation narrative according to the principle of the number seven, from the largest to the smallest level. The number of days, the number of times key words repeat, and even the number of words in the opening and closing paragraphs are all chosen with regard to the number seven.

### Genesis 1:1-2

- a - In the **beginning Elohim created the skies and the land** [7 words]
- b - Now, the land was wild and waste  
and darkness was over the face of the deep-waters [14 words]
- a' - but the spirit of **Elohim** was **fluttering** over the waters

### Six days of God’s forming and filling

### Genesis 2:1-3

#### Day 7

- a - And so they were **finished, the skies and the land** [5 words]
- b - and God **completed** on the **seventh** day his work which he had **made**, [7 words]  
and he **rested** on the **seventh** day from all his work which he had **made**, [7 words]  
and God **blessed** the **seventh** day and he **made it holy** [7 words]
- a' - because on it he rested from all of his work which **Elohim created** to make [9 words]

*Genesis 1:1-2:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

The letters of the Hebrew alphabet also function as a number system. [Proverbs 10:1](#) begins, “These are the proverbs of Solomon.” The Hebrew letters of the name “Solomon” (*shelomoh* / שלמה) amount to the number 375, precisely the number of proverbs found in Proverbs 10:1-22:16 (Patrick Skehan, *Studies in Israelite Poetry and Wisdom*, 43-44).

## Allusive Paronomasia (Hyperlinked Puns)

In [1 Samuel 25:5-11](#), when Nabal shames David and denies knowing him or his family lineage, his speech echoes all the most important names from the genealogy of David found in [Ruth 4:18-22](#) (discussed in

Moshe Garsiel, *The First Book of Samuel: A Literary Study of Comparative Structures, Analogies, and Parallels*, p. 128).

| 1 Samuel 25:5-11                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | David's Genealogy in Ruth 4:18-22                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| David's words to Nabal (1 Sam. 25:6)<br>"My brother: <b>shalom</b> (שָׁלוֹם) (for) you, and <b>shalom</b> (שָׁלוֹם) (for) your house, and <b>shalom</b> (שָׁלוֹם) (for) everything you have ..."                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Perez</b> (פֶּרֶץ)<br>Hezron<br>Ram<br>Amminadab<br>Nahshon<br><b>Salmon/Solomon</b> (שְׁלֹמֹה)<br>Boaz<br><b>Obed</b> (עֹבֵד)<br><b>Jesse</b> (יֵשׁוּ)<br><b>David</b> (דָּוִד) <b>who was...</b><br><b>... born in Bethlehem</b> (בֵּית לֶחֶם = "house of bread") |
| Nabal's words to David (1 Sam. 25:10-11)<br>Who is <b>David</b> (דָּוִד)?<br>And who is the <b>son of Jesse</b> (יֵשׁוּ)?<br>Today many <b>servants</b> (עֲבָדִים)<br>are <b>breaking away</b> (פֶּרֶץ)<br><b>each man</b> (אִישׁ)<br>from before his master,<br>and should I take <b>my bread</b> (לֶחֶם) ...<br>and give it to men I don't know?! |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 1 Samuel Echoes Ruth. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

Symmetrical Design

Micro-Level Forward Symmetry: Isaiah 44:3

|                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|
| A For <b>I will pour out water</b> on the thirsty land |
| B and <b>streams</b> on the dry ground;                |
| A' <b>I will pour out my spirit</b> on your offspring  |
| B' and <b>my blessing</b> on your descendants;         |

Isaiah 44:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024)

Micro-Level Inverse Symmetry: Psalm 137:6

|                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| A If I <b>forget</b> you Jerusalem                            |
| B <b>let my right hand</b> <b>wither</b> ;                    |
| B' <b>let my tongue</b> <b>stick</b> to the roof of my mouth, |
| A' if I <b>don't remember</b> you                             |

Symmetrical Organization of an Entire Literary Unit: Jesus’ Kingdom of God Parables in Matthew 13

|                                                                                                                                          |                                               |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 13:3-9                                                                                                                                   | Parable of the four soils [longest]           |
| 13:18-23                                                                                                                                 | Interpretation of the four soils parable      |
| 13:24-30                                                                                                                                 | Parable of the wheat and weeds [long]         |
| 13:31-32                                                                                                                                 | Parable of the mustard seed [short]           |
| 13:33                                                                                                                                    | Parable of the leaven [short]                 |
| 13:37-43                                                                                                                                 | Interpretation of the wheat and weeds parable |
| 13:44                                                                                                                                    | Parable of hidden treasure [short]            |
| 13:45-46                                                                                                                                 | Parable of the pearl [short]                  |
| 13:47-48                                                                                                                                 | Parable of the fishnet [long]                 |
| 13:49-50                                                                                                                                 | Interpretation of the parable of the fishnet  |
| 13:52                                                                                                                                    | Parable of the scribe [shortest]              |
| Symmetrical Parables in Matthew 13. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                               |

Macro-Level Whole-Scroll Symmetry: The Gospel According to Matthew



Matthew 1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).



# Recovering a Historical Poetics of the Hebrew Bible and Jewish Literature

Understanding the Bible as ancient Jewish meditation literature is a venture in cross-cultural communication. It is an attempt to read these texts sympathetically and to try, to the best of our ability, to read and receive them along the “grain of their design.”

The above literary techniques bear witness to a clear intentionality of design and compositional style that can be called a poetics of literature. We say “recovering” because literary conventions are unique to every cultural and social location. We need to do our best to rediscover what expectations the biblical authors had of their readers.

What I am interested in, above all, is in understanding the nature of Hebrew literary composition, in exhibiting the structural patterns that are employed for the fashioning of a literary unit, whether in poetry or prose, and in discerning the many and various devices by which the predications are formulated and ordered into a unified whole. Such an enterprise I should describe as rhetoric and the methodology as rhetorical criticism.

Muilenburg, James (1969). “[Form Criticism and Beyond](#).” *Journal of Biblical Literature*, Vol. 88, No. 1. The Society of Biblical Literature. 8.

As we discover how to read the Bible as meditation literature, we want to gain native competence in reading ancient Jewish literature and learn how to read the Bible on its own terms. We aim to recover a way of engaging Scripture that is in sync with its design, moving along the grain of its composition rather than against it. In doing so, we hope to read the Bible in the same way Jesus, the apostles, and other Second Temple Jews did.

# Session 2: The Biblical Authors' Toolkit

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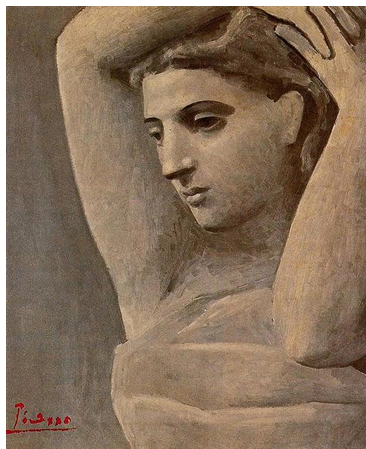
## Key Takeaways

- Biblical literature does not conform to modern conventions of storytelling. We can miss the message of the biblical authors if we expect the Bible to communicate like a modern text.
- Biblical literature frequently uses aspectival representation to communicate its message, presenting seemingly incongruent depictions of ideas or events side by side to portray a more dynamic perspective.
- The biblical authors use many forms of parallelism—representing ideas in coordinated, connected sets—in all different types of biblical literature (e.g., poetry, narrative, chronicle, prophecy).
- The authors use symmetrical design to organize the biblical text into a literary unity. Their design allows the connection and coordination of ideas within the smallest literary unit, as well as within entire scrolls, and even among the whole collection of scrolls.

## Three Foundational Concepts for Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature

### 1. Aspectival Representation Versus Perspectival Representation

Consider these two paintings by Pablo Picasso, one from early in his career and the other from later in his career. They are both about the same subject, a woman with her arms raised.



Picasso, Pablo (1922). *Bust of a Woman, Arms Raised*. [WikiArt.org](https://www.wikiart.org/en/Pablo-Picasso/Bust-of-a-Woman-Arms-Raised).



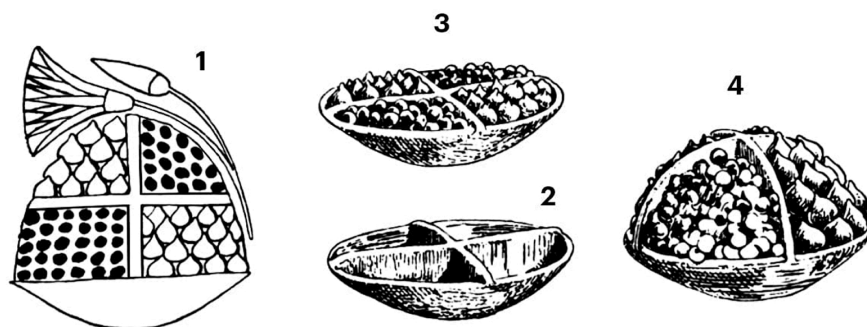
Picasso, Pablo (1936). *Woman with Raised Arms*. [Museopicassomalaga.org](http://Museopicassomalaga.org).

A review from May 1, 1911 in *The Craftsman* reads, "Picasso does not want to see nature, but how he feels about nature. ... But if Picasso is sincerely revealing in his studies the way he feels about nature, it is hard to see why he is not a raving maniac, for anything more disjointed, disconnected, unrelated, unbeautiful than his presentation ... would be difficult to imagine."

The above quote is clearly from a perspectival point of view. The assumption is that visual art should always depict what one "sees" in "nature." That is, a literal, straightforward depiction as if looking through my own eyeballs.

However, what Picasso offered in his 1936 painting is an aspectival presentation. He gathered up a variety of different aspects of the woman, looking at her from different angles, and then coordinated all of them into a two-dimensional plane. This creates a feeling of juxtaposition, as the artist brings many divergent angles into a single moment for reflection. It requires the viewer to do more work.

Aspectival representation is not only a phenomenon in modern art. Teeter and Tooman cite the groundbreaking work of the Egyptologist Emma Brunner-Traut. Her 1990 book, *Frühformen des Erkennens: Am Beispiel Altägyptens*, shows how early Egyptian art displays a fundamentally different mode of visual representation from that of Western art.



Teeter, David and Tooman, William (1990). "Standards of (In)coherence in Ancient Jewish literature."  
*Brunner-Traut, Frühformen des Erkennens: Am Beispiel Altägyptens*. 116.

1. A New Kingdom Egyptian drawing of a compartmented bowl.
2. A contemporary perspectival drawing of the bowl empty, as found.
3. A contemporary perspectival representation of the bowl as filled.
4. Reconstruction on the assumption that there were bowls with high divisions between compartments.

“[T]he method of observation used for Western art cannot be adopted at all for the study of Egyptian art. ... [W]e cannot understand Egyptian art from the outside, and must instead approach it through its own laws of thought.’ Artistic representation in ancient Egypt is characterized by the sequential juxtaposition of relatively independent parts, or ‘aspects,’ that must be mentally added together to form a whole.”

Teeter, David A. and Tooman, William (2020). “[Standards of \(In\)coherence in Ancient Jewish Literature](#).” *Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel*, Volume 9, Issue 2. 116. Citing Brunner-Traut.

“Aspects, particularly when used in the plural, are only individual glimpses, in which a thing is represented from a particular viewpoint. In aspect lies a basic principle of order. Aspect always contains the idea that it is but one among others. Within it lies an instance of needing to be completed. It makes reference to these other aspects, as each is one-sided. In each aspect, certain things emerge in sharper focus than in others and particular connections become clear. None lays claim to completeness. Indeed, how the individual aspects are unified into an overarching whole—and whether they can be unified at all—remain open.”

Brunner-Traut, Emma (1990). [Frühformen des Erkennens: Am Beispiel Altägyptens](#).” 5. Citing Otto Friedrich Bollnow.

The idea of aspective versus perspective is relevant for the most basic questions of biblical interpretation. How do the two descriptions of the pre-creation state in Genesis 1:2 relate to each other? One depicts a desolate wilderness, the other a dark, chaotic ocean.

<sup>1</sup> In-the-beginning **Elohim** created  
the skies (שמים)  
and **the land** (הארץ) .

<sup>2</sup> Now **the land** (הארץ) was **wild and waste** (תהו ובהו)  
and **darkness** was **over the face** of the **deep** (תהום)

but the Spirit-wind of **Elohim** was hovering **over the face** of **the waters** (המים) .

Genesis 1:1-2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

How does the seven-day creation story in Genesis 1:1-2:3 relate to the single-day Eden story in Genesis 2:4-3:24? The acts of creation take place in a different order, the sequences spread out over differently

structured spans of narrative time, and yet, the stories are juxtaposed.

A perspectival approach would assume (or demand) that the two stories work as a chronological and literal sequence of events. An aspectival approach would allow each story to stand on its own, offering two different ways of imagining the origin and purpose of creation, without having to be coordinated in all of their details.

What do we make of the sudden shifts in God's behavior in biblical narratives? In Exodus 4:1-23, God appears to Moses and commissions him to confront Pharaoh and liberate the Israelites. Then in Exodus 4:24-26, we read, "And Yahweh sought to kill Moses."

A perspectival approach makes us wonder if, at any moment, God might turn on me and punish or even kill me for some mysterious reason, known to God alone. An aspectival approach would invite us to see the moral complexity involved when God enlists any human partner with a compromised past, such as Moses' murder of the Egyptian.

## 2. Parallelism

"There is a certain conformation of the sentences, which is chiefly observable in those passages which frequently occur in Hebrew poetry, in which they treat one subject in many different ways, and dwell upon the same sentiment; when they express the same thing in different words, or different things in a similar form of words: and since this artifice of composition seldom fails to produce an agreeable and measured cadence, we can scarcely doubt it must have imparted to their poetry an exquisite degree of beauty and grace. The correspondence of one verse or line with another, I call Parallelism. When a proposition is delivered, and a second is subjoined to it, or drawn under it, equivalent, or contrasted with it, in sense; or similar to it in the form of grammatical construction; these I call parallel lines; and the words or phrases answering one to another in the corresponding line, I call parallel terms."

Lowth, Robert (2012). [Isaiah](#). 14.

These parallel relationships between structurally matching words open up a gigantic and diverse palette of meaning. The author invites the reader to compare two or more things, making their uniqueness and meaning more visible in the process. The juxtaposition asks the reader to ponder multiple aspects at one time.

For more on the biblical authors' use of these strategies, see Roland Meynet, "[A Treatise on Biblical Rhetoric](#)," 2012, and Robert Lowth, "[Lectures on the Sacred Poetry of the Hebrews](#)," 1753.

## Whole/Part

### Psalm 33:6 NASB\*

By the word of Yahweh **the heavens** were made,  
and by the breath of his mouth **all their host**.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

## Comparison/Analogy

### **Isaiah 44:3 NASB\***

- a - For I will pour out **water on the thirsty land**
- b - and **streams on the dry ground;**
- a' - I will pour out **my Spirit on your offspring**
- b' - and **my blessing on your descendants;**

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

## **Contrast**

### **Proverbs 10:11 NASB**

The mouth of **the righteous is a fountain of life,**  
but the mouth of **the wicked conceals violence.**

## **Complement**

The second line complements the first in a general way. It completes a thought or image, or heightens the point in some way.

### **Psalms 133:1 NASB**

Behold, how good and how pleasant it is  
for brothers to dwell together in unity!

### **Habakkuk 3:2 Instructor's Translation**

- a - Lord, I have heard the report about you; I fear.
- b - Yahweh, renew your work in the midst of the years,
- b' - in the midst of the years make it known;
- a' - in wrath remember mercy.

## **Sequence**

The lines are not parallel in meaning, but develop a short narrative sequence.

### **Psalms 31:1 NASB\***

In you, Yahweh, I have taken refuge;  
let me never be ashamed;  
in your righteousness deliver me.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Psalms 31:22 Instructor's Translation**

As for me, I said in my alarm,  
"I am cut off from before your eyes";  
however, you heard the voice of my petition  
when I cried to you.



## Proverbs 4:10 NASB

Hear, my son, and accept my sayings  
and the years of your life will be many.

### The Function of Repetition, Juxtaposition, and Variegated Poetic Expression

“Speaking in pairs” creates opportunities to use multiple words and images to communicate one core idea from many angles. This type of poetic style is a wonderful way to express complex thoughts through pairing words or images in order to communicate more by means of juxtaposition.

The biblical authors developed vocabulary for this technique. The Hebrew word *mashal* (משל) means “comparison,” “analogy,” or “proverb.”

“The parallel lines of biblical poetry are like a pair of eyes: We look ... with both eyes, so that we have the advantage of seeing depth. Our eye[s] ... see ‘in stereo.’ The effect results from the fact that one eye has a slightly different angle than the other, and so produces a minimally different image. These two pictures are easily superimposed and assembled into one image inside our brain. Biblical parallelism does something comparable: this poetic device creates two subtly different images with two lines that are to be associated through parallel expression. It allows us an opportunity to consider both pictures separately, and then let them sink in together. ... The point of similarity between two parallel lines is their very difference! Only those who look closely and have patience will discover and savor the role played by dissimilarity, its surprises, and its richness of meaning.”

Fokkelman, J.P. (2001). *Reading Biblical Poetry: An Introductory Guide*. Westminster John Knox Press. 78-79.

Consider the cognitive processes of association and analogy set in motion by a simple juxtaposition of images.



Left image: McGregor, Gordon (2007). [GordonMcGregor.BlogSpot.com](http://GordonMcGregor.BlogSpot.com). Right image: Soruyor, Kizlar (2015). [KizlarSoruyor.com](http://KizlarSoruyor.com).

### 3. Symmetrical Design and Analogical Representation

Human cognition is built on a learned process of grouping, comparing, and contrasting all the sensory data that comes our way. We can call this Analogical Cognition (e.g., “This is like that, that is like this,” or “This is not like that, that is not like this”). One of the most basic ways to present a meaningful comparison or contrast is to place two or three things next to each other and meditate on their similarities or differences.

For example, my wife grouped three plants on an old radio we use as a decorative shelf by our dinner table.



© BibleProject

The unique features of each plant become more prominent only once I compare and contrast them with each other.

- All three plants are green.
- Plants One and Two have tan pots, while Plant Three has a cream pot.
- One and Three are big, but Two is small.
- We elevated One and Three, but not Two.
- One and Three have light and dark green, while Two has mainly dark green.
- One has skinny leaves, but Two and Three have thicker, wider leaves.

The process of comparing and contrasting slowly creates a unique profile of each plant as an individual, while showing how similarities unite them. This approach deepens the appreciation for each plant.

For more on the topic, see David A. Teeter, “[Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors](#),” and especially Douglas Hofstadter’s lecture “[Analogy as the Core of Cognition](#)” and book [Surfaces and Essences: Analogy as the Fuel and Fire of Thinking](#).



# Session 3: Meditating on Psalm 1:1-3

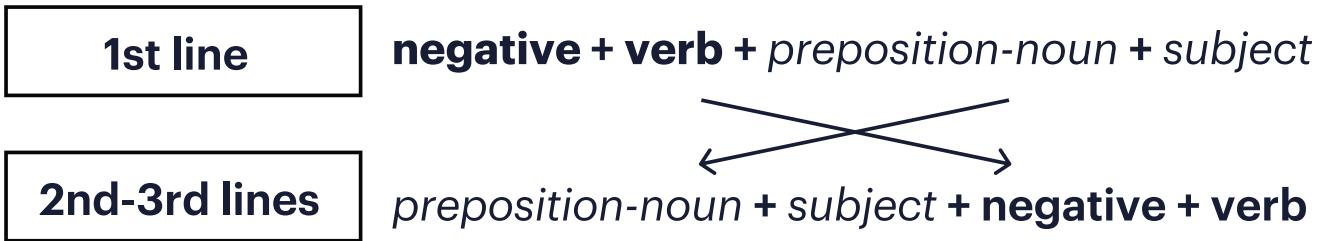
## Key Takeaways

- Psalms 1 and 2 were designed and placed together to communicate a coordinated message. Recognizing this coordination requires meditation on the shared themes and structure.
- The tight coordination and intricate design of Psalm 1 is apparent in its first three-word line. The psalmist uses repeated sounds and symmetry to introduce the set of three statements that follows.
- The good-life man (whose life Psalm 1:1 identifies as “blessed”) is likened to a tree in Psalm 1:3, inviting us to meditate on the way being precedes doing and to contemplate the biblical portrait of success.

## Psalm 1:1

|                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a<br>b<br>b'<br>b''                                                                                             | How good is life for the man who<br><b>doesn't walk</b> <b>by</b> (-ב) <b>the counsel of the wicked</b> ,<br>and <b>in</b> (-ב) <b>the path of sinners</b> <b>he does not stand</b> ,<br>and <b>in</b> (-ב) <b>the seat of mockers</b> <b>he does not sit</b> . | אֲשֶׁר־יִהְיֶה אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר<br>לֹא הָלַךְ בְּעֵצַת רָשָׁעִים<br>וּבְדֶרֶךְ חַטָּאִים לֹא עָמַד<br>וּבִמְוֶשֶׁב לֵצִים לֹא יָשָׁב: |
| Psalm 1:1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                   |

The three opening words are bound together by similar-sounding Hebrew consonants and vowels: 'ashre, ha'ish, 'asher. The three following lines are designed in precise relationship to each other, though the second and third lines invert the word order of the first line.



Inverted Word Order in Psalm 1:1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

This symmetry between the three lines creates an important set of matching relationships. The words “walk,” “stand,” and “sit” create a progression of moving then stopping then settling. The words

“counsel,” “path,” and “seat” take us from thoughts to a way of life to a settled location. The words “wicked,” “sinners,” and “mockers” go from general to specific.

Psalm 1:2

|    |                                                         |                                                |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| a  | Rather, <b>in</b> (-ב) the <b>instruction</b> of Yahweh | כִּי אִם בְּתוֹרַת יְהוָה חִפְצוֹ <sup>2</sup> |
| b  | is <b>his delight</b>                                   |                                                |
| a' | and <b>on</b> (-ב) his <b>instruction</b>               | וּבְתוֹרָתוֹ יִהְיֶה יוֹמָם וּלְיָלָה:         |
| b' | <b>he meditates</b> day and night.                      |                                                |

Psalm 1:2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

This verse consists of four parts, arranged in a forward symmetry (aba'b'). The symmetry invites the reader to notice the verbatim repetition of “instruction” (Hebrew: *torah*).

The similarity between the a line and a' line draws attention to the dissimilarity between the b lines. Delight parallels meditation. Whatever captures our delight draws us to meditate on it. If something is beautiful, enjoyable, and captivating, no one has to tell us to focus our attention on it. We just do.

In biblical Hebrew, “meditation” (*hagah*) does not primarily refer to a purely mental activity, but rather a focusing of one’s mind and a quiet whisper-like recitation.

Job 27:3-4 NASB\*

For as long as life is in me, and the breath of God is in my nostrils,  
my lips certainly will not speak unjustly, nor will my tongue **hagah** deceit.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 63:6 NASB\*

When I remember you on my bed,  
I **hagah** on you in the night watches,

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 71:23-24 NASB\*

My lips will shout for joy when I sing praises to you; and my soul, which you have redeemed.  
My tongue also will **hagah** your righteousness all day long;

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 8:19 NASB\*

When they say to you, “Consult the mediums and the spiritists who whisper and **hagah**,” should not a people consult their God? Should they consult the dead on behalf of the living?

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Elsewhere, authors use the verb to describe the quiet sounds made by various creatures.

**Isaiah 31:4 NASB\***

For thus says the Lord to me, “As the lion or the young lion **hagah** over his prey, against which a band of shepherds is called out, and he will not be terrified at their voice nor disturbed at their noise ...”

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Isaiah 38:14 NASB\***

Like a swallow, like a crane, so I twitter; I **hagah** like a dove; my eyes look wistfully to the heights; O Lord, I am oppressed, be my security.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

**Psalms 1:1-2**

|                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a<br>b<br>b'<br>b''                                                                                                | How good is life for the man who<br><b>doesn't walk by (-ב) the counsel of the wicked</b> ,<br>and <b>in (-ב) the path of</b> sinners <b>he does not stand</b> ,<br>and <b>in (-ב) the seat of</b> mockers <b>he does not sit</b> . | אֲשֶׁר־יֵהְיֶה אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר<br>לֹא הָלַךְ בְּעֵצַת רָשָׁעִים<br>וּבְדֶרֶךְ חַטָּאִים לֹא עָמַד<br>וּבִמְוֶשֶׁב לֵצִים לֹא יָשָׁב: |
| a<br>b<br>a'<br>b'                                                                                                 | Rather, <b>in (-ב) the instruction of Yahweh</b><br>is <b>his delight</b><br>and <b>on (-ב) his instruction</b><br><b>he meditates</b> day and night.                                                                               | כִּי אִם בְּתוֹרַת יְהוָה חִפְצוֹ<br>וּבְתוֹרָתוֹ יִהְיֶה יוֹמָם וּלְיָלָה:                                                       |
| Psalms 1:1-2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                   |

Notice how the *bet* prepositions unite all of verses 1-2, drawing attention to the contrast. In verse 1, we see “does NOT walk/stand/sit ... by/on/in ...” In verse 2, we see “does delight/meditate ... in/on ...”

Notice also that “counsel of the wicked” provides a contrast with “instruction of Yahweh.” Both words involve the sharing of ideas that guide one’s actions and way of life.

**Psalms 1:3**

|                                                                                                                 |                                                                             |                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| a                                                                                                               | And <b>he</b> will become <b>like a tree</b> (כֵּעֵץ) planted by streams of | וְהָיָה כֵּעֵץ שְׁתוּל עַל-פְּלִי מַיִם <sup>3</sup> |
| b                                                                                                               | water,                                                                      | אֲשֶׁר פִּרְיוֹ יִתֵּן בְּעֵתוֹ                      |
| b'                                                                                                              | which gives <b>its fruit</b> in its time,                                   | וְעֵלְהוּ לֹא-יִבּוֹל                                |
| a'                                                                                                              | and <b>its leaf</b> does not wither,                                        | וְכָל אֲשֶׁר-יַעֲשֶׂה יִצְלִיחַ:                     |
|                                                                                                                 | and everything <b>he</b> will do, he makes successful.                      |                                                      |
| Psalm 1:3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                             |                                                      |

The human/tree simile centered around the words tree, fruit, and leaf links together the first three lines. The outer lines (a and a') explicitly describe the human of verse 1, "he will become ..." and "he will do ...." The inner lines (b and b') work fully within the tree metaphor, using various plant parts as images of a fruitful human life ("its fruit" and "its leaf").

## Psalm 1:4

|                                                                                                                 |                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Not so <b>the wicked</b> ;<br>rather, he is like chaff<br>which is driven away by wind,                         | לֹא-כֵן הַרְשָׁעִים <sup>4</sup><br>כִּי אִם-כֶּמֶץ אֲשֶׁר-תִּדְפֶּנּוּ רוּחַ: |
| Psalm 1:4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                                |

The contrasting conjunction ("not so") explicitly presumes the previous description of the righteous in verse 3, so that the wicked man acts as a foil to the tree-man. The "rather" (כִּי אִם) clause offers the reason why the wicked man is "not so."

## Psalm 1:3 and 1:4 Compared

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| And <b>he</b> will become <b>like a tree</b> (כֵּעֵץ) planted by streams of water,<br><b>which</b> (אֲשֶׁר) gives its fruit in its time,<br>and its leaf does not wither,<br>and everything <b>which</b> (אֲשֶׁר) he does, he makes it successful (יִצְלִיחַ). | וְהָיָה כֵּעֵץ שְׁתוּל עַל-פְּלִי מַיִם <sup>3</sup><br>אֲשֶׁר פִּרְיוֹ יִתֵּן בְּעֵתוֹ<br>וְעֵלְהוּ לֹא-יִבּוֹל<br>וְכָל אֲשֶׁר-יַעֲשֶׂה יִצְלִיחַ: |
| Not so <b>the wicked</b> ;<br>rather, he is <b>like chaff</b> (כֶּמֶץ)<br><b>which</b> (אֲשֶׁר) is driven away by wind (רוּחַ).                                                                                                                                | לֹא-כֵן הַרְשָׁעִים <sup>4</sup><br>כִּי אִם-כֶּמֶץ אֲשֶׁר-תִּדְפֶּנּוּ רוּחַ:                                                                       |
| Psalm 1:3-4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                      |

These two lines provide an explicit contrast between the Torah meditator (“he”) and “the wicked” as both are the subject of the first words of each verse. The similes “like a tree” (Hebrew: **כֵּץ**) and “like chaff” (**כֶּמֶץ**) are each three-letter words spelled with identical first and last consonants, inviting a contrast between a fruitful tree and withered, dried-out plant matter.

The passage describes each figure with a subordinate clause that begins with “which” (**אֲשֶׁר**). The final line of each consists of ten syllables that follow a matching cadence with the one shared word (“which” / **אֲשֶׁר**) and many similar sounding consonants and vowels, creating a “rhyming” feel. The similarities of sound draw attention to their contrasting fates, success versus being driven away.

- **1:3d** vekhol ‘asher ya’aseh yatsliakh
- **1:4b** ki ‘im kammots ‘asher tiddephennu ruakh

## Psalm 1:1-2 Compared with Psalm 1:3-4

A <sup>1</sup> **How good is life** (**אֲשֶׁר**) for the man  
**who** (**אֲשֶׁר**) does **not** walk **by the counsel of** (**בְּעֵצָה**) the wicked,  
 and in the path of sinners he does **not** stand,  
 and in the seat of mockers he does **not sit**.

B <sup>2</sup> **Rather** (**כִּי אִם**), in the instruction of Yahweh  
 is his delight  
 and on his instruction  
 he meditates day and night.

A' <sup>3</sup> And he will become like a tree **planted** by streams of water,  
**which** (**אֲשֶׁר**) gives its fruit **in its time** (**בְּעֵתוֹ**),  
 and its leaf does **not** wither,  
 and everything **which** (**אֲשֶׁר**) he does, he makes it successful.

B' <sup>4</sup> Not so the wicked;  
**Rather** (**כִּי אִם**), he is like chaff  
 which is driven away by wind,

*Psalm 1:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024)*

When one considers all of verses 1-4, one perceives a set of features that unite verses 1 and 3 and verses 2 and 4 as a forward symmetry (ABA'B').

## Features Linking Verses 1 and 3

The double use of אשר/אשרי ("how good is life"/"who") in verse 1 is matched by the double אשר ("which") in verse 3. The consonants of "by the counsel of" (בעצת) match those of "in its time" (בעתו), inviting a comparison.

"Counsel" is a typical word for the planning and timing of future actions in a strategy to accomplish a goal. The wicked constantly have to counsel the success of their future plans. The Torah meditator will naturally find success "in its time," that is, in the appropriate season that God appoints. It is a subtle contrast between human timing and divine timing, between human strategies for fruitfulness versus God's providential guidance.

The triple negative "not" of verse 1 echoes in the negative of verse 3, "not wither." Notice the matched synonyms of "sit" (ישב) in verse 1 and "planted" (שתול) in verse 3. Instead of being settled in the seat of mockers, he is planted in the river of life.

## Features Linking Verses 2 and 3

The central description of the Torah meditator juxtaposes two words for time. In verse 2, "day and night" conveys the idea of constant time. In verse 3, "in its time" suggests not constant but consistent, seasonal passage of time.

## Features Linking Verses 2 and 4

Both contain the identical contrast phrase "rather" (כי אם). In verse 2, rather contrasts the Torah meditator with the wicked ones of verse 1. In verse 4, rather contrasts the wicked with the Torah meditator of verses 2-3. However, if one attends to a different set of features, an inverse symmetrical shape (i.e., a chiasm, ABB'A') can be discerned in verses 1-4.

- A <sup>1</sup> **How good is life** (אשרי) for the man  
    **who** (אשר) does not walk by the counsel of **the wicked** ,  
    and in the path of sinners he does not stand,  
    and in the seat of mockers he does not sit.
- B <sup>2</sup> Rather, in the instruction of Yahweh  
    is his delight  
    and on his instruction  
    he meditates **day and night** .

B' <sup>3</sup> And he will become like a tree planted by streams of water,  
which gives its fruit in its time,  
and its leaf does not wither,  
and everything which he does, he makes it successful.

A' <sup>4</sup> Not so **the wicked** ;  
Rather, he is like chaff  
**which** (אשר) is driven away by wind,

*Psalm 1:1-4 v2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024)*

The wicked appear as the focus of the beginning and end, while the central lines describe the Torah meditator.

A (v. 1) The wicked/sinner/mockers

B (v. 2) Torah meditator day and night

B' (v. 3) Like a tree giving fruit in time

A' (v. 4) The wicked



# Session 4: Meditating on Psalm 1:4-6

## Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors use words that look similar to create connections within the text. For example, the Hebrew words for “like a tree” (*ke’ets* / כַּעֵץ) and “like chaff” (*kammots* / כַּמֹּץ) in Psalm 1:3-4 differ by only one consonant and look very similar.
- Biblical literature is art. As such, it operates in both subjective and objective ways. The intricate design of these psalms leads readers on a journey of meditation in which the subjective and the objective come together.
- Just because a structural relationship links two ideas does not mean they are the same. The connection invites us to meditate on the relationship between them.

## Psalm 1:5

|                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Therefore, <b>the wicked</b> will <b>not</b> stand <b>in the judgment</b> ,<br><b>nor</b> sinners <b>in the assembly</b> of <b>the righteous</b> , | עַל־כֵּן לֹא־יָקֻמוּ רָשָׁעִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט<br>וְחַטָּאִים בְּעֵדֹת צְדִיקִים: |
| Psalm 1:5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).                                    |                                                                                 |

The author designed these two lines in such a tight symmetrical shape that the verb from the a line can be omitted and implied in the b line. This design shape creates a clear series of word-matches. First, “wicked/sinner” and “righteous.” Then, “the judgment” and “the assembly of the righteous.”

This final word pair, “judgment” and “assembly of the righteous,” invites the reader to meditate on how the judgment relates to the assembly of the righteous. The act of judgment in the Hebrew Bible refers to the decision given by a judge in a dispute. The guilty one is declared to be in the wrong, and the one in the right is declared righteous.

**Exodus 23:6-7 Instructor's Translation**

You will not distort **the judgment** due to your needy brother in his dispute.  
Keep far from a false charge, and do not put the innocent or the righteous to death, for I will not declare **righteous** (צַדִּיק = the one in the right) the **wicked** (רָשָׁע = the one in the wrong).

The verb “to stand” appears only in the a line but is implied in both poetic lines. It has a slightly different nuance in each. In the a line, we see the idea of not being able to stand when God arrives to deliver final justice, a common motif in the prophets.

### Malachi 3:1-2 NASB

“Behold, I am going to send my messenger, and he will clear the way before me. And the Lord, whom you seek, will suddenly come to his temple; and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, he is coming,” says the Lord of hosts. “But who can endure the day of his coming? And **who can stand when he appears?** For he is like a refiner’s fire and like fullers’ soap.”

### Nahum 1:5-6 NASB

Mountains quake because of him and the hills dissolve; indeed the earth is upheaved by his presence, the world and all the inhabitants in it. **Who can stand before his indignation?** Who can endure the burning of his anger? His wrath is poured out like fire and the rocks are broken up by him.

### Psalms 130:3 LEB

If you, O Yah, should keep track of iniquities, O Lord, **who could stand?**

### Psalms 76:7-8 NASB

You, even you, are to be feared; and **who may stand in your presence** when once you are angry?  
**You caused judgment to be heard** from heaven; the earth feared and was still

In the b line, the idea of “not standing in the assembly” means not being counted among the community who stand in right relationship with God.

## Psalms 1:4-5 Compared

|                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <sup>4</sup> <b>Not so</b> (לא כן) <b>the wicked</b> ;<br>Rather, he is like chaff that <b>the wind</b> drives away,                                              | <sup>4</sup> לא־כֵן הַרְשָׁעִים<br>כִּי אִם-כֶּמֶץ אֲשֶׁר-תִּדְפֶּנּוּ רוּחַ:                |
| <sup>5</sup> <b>Therefore</b> (על כן), <b>the wicked</b> will not stand <b>in the judgment</b> ,<br>nor <b>sinner</b> s in the assembly of <b>the righteous</b> , | <sup>5</sup> עַל־כֵּן לֹא־יִקְמוּ רְשָׁעִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט<br>וְחַטָּאִים בְּעֵדֶת צְדִיקִים: |
| <i>Psalms 1:4-5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).</i>                                         |                                                                                              |

Verses 4 and 5 both begin with logical connector words that rhyme and match in Hebrew. Verse 4 begins with *lo’ khi* / לא כן and verse 5 begins with *’al khi* / על כן. This connection prompts the reader to compare the statements. Verse 4 contrasts the wicked with the righteous of verse 3. Verse 5 offers the logical conclusion of that very contrast between verses 3 and 4. This rhyming emphasizes the contrasting and binary fates of the righteous and the wicked.

Notice how the inner lines of verses 4 and 5, taken as a unit, pair “the wind” with “the judgment,” drawing on the common motif of storms as an image of divine judgment.

### Isaiah 4:4 LEB\*

when the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion and cleansed the bloodshed of Jerusalem from her midst by a **wind of judgment** (רוח משפט) and by a **wind of burning**.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 1:6

|                                                                                                                 |                                                                       |                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| a b                                                                                                             | because Yahweh <b>knows</b> <b>the path of</b> <b>the righteous</b> , | כִּי־יֹדֵעַ יְהוָה דֶּרֶךְ צְדִיקִים <sup>6</sup> |
| b' a'                                                                                                           | but <b>the path of</b> <b>the wicked</b> <b>will perish</b> .         | וְדֶרֶךְ רָשָׁעִים תֵּאבֵד:                       |
| Psalm 1:6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                       |                                                   |

Notice how the author designed the two lines with inverted opposites in word order. This emphasizes the inversion of the fates experienced by the righteous and the wicked.

- Yahweh knows (a) / the path of the righteous (b)
- but the path of the wicked (b') / it will perish (a')

Also, “knows” (Hebrew: yodea’) and “will perish” (to’ved), the verbs in each line, have a rhyming vowel pattern.

Psalm 1:5-6 Compared

|                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A                                                                                                                 | <sup>5</sup> <b>Therefore</b> (עַל כֵּן), <b>the wicked</b> will <b>not</b> (לֹא) stand in                                                             | עַל־כֵּן לֹא־יִקְמוּ רָשָׁעִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט <sup>5</sup>                        |
| B                                                                                                                 | <b>the judgment</b> ,<br>nor <b>sinners</b> in the assembly of <b>the righteous</b> ,                                                                  | וְחֹטְאִים בְּעֵדֶת צְדִיקִים:                                                   |
| B'<br>A'                                                                                                          | <sup>6</sup> <b>because</b> (כִּי) Yahweh knows the path of <b>the</b><br><b>righteous</b> ,<br>but the path of <b>the wicked</b> <b>will perish</b> . | כִּי־יֹדֵעַ יְהוָה דֶּרֶךְ צְדִיקִים <sup>6</sup><br>וְדֶרֶךְ רָשָׁעִים תֵּאבֵד: |
| Psalm 1:5-6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                  |

Notice how the words fall into an inverse symmetrical pattern of wicked > righteous > righteous > wicked. It is as if the inside-out order of the words portrays the reversal that the words describe. As the wicked face their own ruin in divine judgment, the righteous are vindicated and known by Yahweh.

The “judgment” in Psalm 1:5a correlates to “will perish” in 1:6b. “Assembly of the righteous” in 1:5b is connected to the “path of the righteous” in 1:6a.

# Psalms 1:1-6 in Forward and Inverse Symmetry

Psalms 1 has features that display both a forward symmetrical design (ABC > A'B'C') as well as an inverse symmetrical design (ABC > C'B'A'), known as a chiasm.

## Forward Symmetrical Links

### Wicked Path

- a 1 How good is life for **the man**  
A b who **doesn't walk** by **the counsel of** (בעצת) **the wicked**,  
b' and in the **path** of **sinners** **he does not stand**,  
b'' and in the seat of **mockers** **he does not** **sit**.

### Divine Instruction

- a 2 **Rather**, in the **instruction** of **Yahweh**  
B b is **his delight**  
a' and on his **instruction**  
b' **he meditates** day and night.

### Righteous = Tree

- a 3 And he becomes **like a tree** (כעץ) **planted** by streams of water,  
C b which gives **its fruit** in its time,  
b' and **its leaf** does not wither,  
a' and everything he does, he makes successful.

### Wicked = Chaff

- A' 4 **Not so** **the wicked**;  
**rather**, he is **like chaff** (כמץ) that **the wind drives away**.

### Divine Justice

- B' abc 5 **Therefore**, **the wicked** **does not stand** in **the judgment**,  
b'c' nor **sinners** in **the assembly of** (בעדת) **the righteous**,

### Wicked Path vs. Righteous Path

- C' abc 6 **because** **Yahweh** knows the **path** of **the righteous**,  
b'c'a' but the **path** of **the wicked** **perishes**.

*Psalms 1*. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

## Psalm 1:1 and 1:4

“The wicked” appears in both verses. We see the term in verse 4 for the first time since it appeared in verse 1. In verse 1, the man does not enter into association with the wicked. In verse 4, the wicked are altogether removed from any association with others.

## Psalm 1:2 and 1:5

In verse 2, the “instruction” (Hebrew: *torah*) is Yahweh’s. However, in verse 5, “the judgment” is ambiguous. Whose judgment is the author referring to? In Psalm 119, Yahweh’s instruction and judgment are often set in relationship with each other, so that one is to see both instruction and judgment as coming from Yahweh.

The connection between verses 2 and 5 brings the “meditator” and “the righteous” into a clear association. They are one and the same person.

## Psalm 1:3 and 1:6

Verse 3 depicts the righteous man as a fruitful tree, planted by a stream that is metaphorically associated with Yahweh’s instruction. In parallel, verse 6 depicts the righteous as known by Yahweh. In both images, Yahweh is the source and provider for his people. The fruitfulness of the righteous tree-man in verse 3 stands in contrast to the “perishing” of verse 6.

## Inverse Symmetrical Links

### Wicked Path

- a <sup>1</sup> How good is life for **the man**  
A b who **doesn’t walk** by **the counsel of** (בעצת) **the wicked**,  
b' and in the **path** of **sinners** **he does not stand**,  
b'' and in the seat of **mockers** **he does not** **sit**.

### Divine Instruction

- a <sup>2</sup> **Rather**, in the **instruction** of **Yahweh**  
B b is **his delight**  
a' and on his **instruction**  
b' **he meditates** day and night.

### Righteous = Tree

- a <sup>3</sup> And he becomes **like a tree** (כעץ) **planted** by streams of water,  
C b which gives **its fruit** in its time,  
b' and **its leaf** does not wither,  
a' and everything he does, he makes successful.

### Wicked = Chaff

C' 4 **Not so** the wicked ;  
rather, he is like chaff (כֶּמֶץ) that the wind drives away.

### Divine Justice

B' abc 5 **Therefore**, the wicked does not stand in the judgment,  
b'c' nor sinners in the assembly of (בְּעֵדָת) the righteous ,

### Wicked Path vs. Righteous Path

A' abc 6 **because** Yahweh knows the path of the righteous ,  
b'c'a' but the path of the wicked perishes.

*Psalms 1:1-6 Symmetry. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024)*

### Psalms 1:1 and 1:6

The “wicked” are contrasted with “the man” (verse 1) and “the righteous” (verse 6), but in different ways. Their contrary ways of life are the focus of verse 1, while their contrasting fates are the emphasis of verse 6.

The word “path” (*derekh*) appears only in these opening and closing lines of the poem. The metaphorical scheme of “life as a journey on a path” is activated in terms of both patterns of behavior (“a way” in verse 1) and behavior and its consequences (“a way” in verse 6).

### Psalms 1:2 and 1:5

As with the forward symmetrical link, the connection between verses 2 and 5 brings the “meditator” and “the righteous” into a clear association. They are one and the same person.

### Psalms 1:3 and 1:4

The righteous portrayed as a “tree” (עֵץ) and the wicked envisioned as “chaff” (כֶּמֶץ) are similar in terms of letters but different in terms of meaning. The fruitful tree versus dry chaff gives a stark contrast.

This juxtaposition also relates the two sources of the action in each verse. In verse 3, we see “water” (מַיִם). In verse 4, we have “wind” (רוּחַ). These two images are combined elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, where we see God’s Spirit pouring out like water.

### Isaiah 32:15 LEB

Until a spirit is poured out on us from on high,  
and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field,  
and the fruitful field is reckoned as the forest.

### Isaiah 44:3 LEB

For I will pour out water on a thirsty land  
and streams on dry ground.

I will **pour my spirit out** on your descendants  
and my blessing on your offspring.

#### **Ezekiel 39:29 LEB**

“And I will not hide my face again from them when **I pour out my Spirit** over the house of Israel,”  
declares the Lord Yahweh.

#### **Joel 2:28–29 LEB**

And it will happen afterward thus:  
I will **pour out my Spirit** on all flesh,  
and your sons and your daughters will prophesy,  
and your elders will dream dreams;  
your young men shall see visions.  
And also on the male slaves and on the female slaves,  
I will **pour out my Spirit** in those days.

#### **Zechariah 12:10 LEB**

**I will pour out** on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem **a spirit** of grace and  
supplication, and they will look to me whom they pierced, and they shall mourn over him, as one wails  
over an only child, and they will grieve bitterly over him as one grieves bitterly over a firstborn.



## Module 2: The Bible's Interwoven Connections in Psalms 1 and 2

### SESSIONS 5-9

Apply skills for tracing patterns and repeated words in Psalms 1 and 2, and see how the Bible's deeply connected structure leads to a lifetime of meditation.



# Session 5: Meditating on Psalm 2:1-6

## Key Takeaways

- Psalm 2 begins with a dense cluster of words about people: nations, peoples, kings, rulers, and God’s anointed one. It contrasts the plotting of the many with the established plan of God, centered on the one.
- When the kings of the earth plot their rebellion against God’s plan, the unspoken subtext is that those facing the immediate consequences of their actions are not the powerful, but those who lack the influence to avoid the fallout.
- Psalm 2:1-6 shares many words and ideas with Psalm 1, but often with inverted emphasis, like how the rebellious ones “meditate emptiness” in 2:1 (see 1:2) or God being the one who “mocks” in 2:4 (see 1:1).
- The turmoil on the land versus God’s unperturbed reign in the skies creates a striking contrast. The anointed king revealed on the Heaven-meets-Earth mountain of Zion serves as an answer to the disconnect between Heaven and Earth.

## Psalm 2:1-3

|                                                                                                                   |                    |                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A<br>B                                                                                                            | a<br>a'            | <sup>1</sup> Why do <b>the nations</b> <b>rage</b> ,<br>and <b>the peoples</b> <b>meditate</b> emptiness?                                                                    | <sup>1</sup> לָמָּה רָגְשׁוּ גּוֹיִם<br>וְלְאֻמִּים יִהְגְּדִיק:                                         |
| A'<br>B'<br>C<br>C'                                                                                               | a<br>a'<br>b<br>b' | <sup>2</sup> The <b>kings</b> of the land take their stand,<br>and <b>the rulers</b> take counsel together<br>against <b>Yahweh</b><br>and against <b>his anointed one</b> , | <sup>2</sup> יִתְּצֵבּוּ מְלָכֵי-אֶרֶץ<br>וְרוֹזְנִים נִסְדְּדוּ-יַחַד<br>עַל-יְהוָה<br>וְעַל-מְשִׁיחוֹ: |
| D<br>D'                                                                                                           | a<br>a'            | <sup>3</sup> “ <b>Let’s</b> tear apart <b>their</b> bonds,<br>and <b>let’s</b> cast off from us <b>their</b> cords!”                                                         | <sup>3</sup> נִגְתָּקָה אֶת-מוֹסְרוֹתֵינוּ<br>וְנִשְׁלִיכָהּ מִמֶּנּוּ עֲבֹתֵינוּ:                       |
| Psalm 2:1-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                    |                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                          |

Psalm 2:1 consists of two lines. Each line is three words in Hebrew. Both lines begin with words that match in spelling and sound. Psalm 2:1a has “why” (Hebrew: *lammah* / לָמָּה) while in 2:1b we see “peoples” (*le’ummim* / לְאֻמִּים). The sentence word-order sequence switches in an inverse symmetry, in order to

create the assonance pairing observed above.

|                                                                                                                 | A         | B                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-------------------------|
| 2:1a                                                                                                            | they rage | nations                 |
|                                                                                                                 | B'        | A'                      |
| 2:1b                                                                                                            | peoples   | they meditate emptiness |
| Psalm 2:1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |           |                         |

Two lines, each with two parts, make up Psalm 2:2. Verse 2:2a consists of two complete sentences, also in an inverse symmetry.

|                                                                                                                  | A                 | B                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|
| 2:2a                                                                                                             | they take a stand | kings of the land     |
|                                                                                                                  | B'                | A'                    |
| 2:2a                                                                                                             | and rulers        | they counsel together |
| Psalm 2:2a. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                   |                       |

Verse 2:2b follows with two prepositional phrases that function as a dual indirect object to both verbs in 2:2a, “against Yahweh” then “and against his anointed one.”

Psalm 2:3 shifts into an unmarked speech by the “kings of the land.” The “let us” refers back to the rulers and nations of verses 1-2. The possessive pronoun “their” refers back to Yahweh and his anointed one of verse 2. The author created forward symmetry with the word order, which also draws attention to the rhyming of the unique verbal and pronoun forms.

|                                                                                                                 | A                                                     | B                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 2:3a                                                                                                            | let’s tear apart<br><b>ne</b> <i>natte</i> <b>qah</b> | their bonds<br><i>mosrot</i> <b>emo</b> |
|                                                                                                                 | A'                                                    | B'                                      |
| Psalm 2:3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                       |                                         |

|                                                                                                                 |                                       |                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 2:3b                                                                                                            | let's cast off<br><i>na shli khah</i> | from us their cords<br>'avot <i>emo</i> |
| Psalm 2:3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                       |                                         |

Psalm 2:1-3 As a Whole

The triad of lines holds together as a coherent narrative sequence. The world rulers are the subject of all the verbs in Psalm 2:1-3. Verse 1 mentions their “meditative muttering,” and verse 3 gives us the “empty” content of their muttering. It is a futile resistance speech.

Psalm 2:4-6

|                                                                                                                   |              |                                                                                          |                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| A<br>B<br><br>C<br>C'<br><br>B'<br>A'                                                                             | a b<br>a' b' | 4 The one sitting in the skies, he laughs ,<br>the master mocks at them ,                | 4 יושב בשמים ישחק<br>אדני ילעג־למו:     |
|                                                                                                                   | a b<br>b' a' | 5 then he will speak to them in his anger<br>and in his hot-anger he will terrify them , | 5 אז ידבר אלימו באפו<br>ובחרונו יבהלמו: |
|                                                                                                                   | a<br>b       | 6 “As for me, I have anointed my King ,<br>upon Zion, my holy mountain.”                 | 6 ואני נסכתי מלכי<br>על־ציון הר־קדשי:   |
| Psalm 2:4-6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |              |                                                                                          |                                         |

Psalm 2:4 consists of two poetic lines of three Hebrew words each in a forward symmetry.

|                                                                                                                 |                          |               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|---------------|
|                                                                                                                 | A                        | B             |
| 2:4a                                                                                                            | one sitting in the skies | he laughs     |
|                                                                                                                 | A'                       | B'            |
| 2:4b                                                                                                            | the master               | he mocks them |
| Psalm 2:4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                          |               |

Psalm 2:5 follows with the time sequence marker “then” (Hebrew: ‘az / אז) and two lines set in an inverse symmetry.

|                                                                                                                 | A                                                   | B                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 2:5a                                                                                                            | he speaks to them<br>yedabber 'el <b>emo</b>        | in his anger<br><b>v</b> e'app <b>o</b> |
|                                                                                                                 | B'                                                  | A'                                      |
| 2:5b                                                                                                            | and in his hot anger<br>u <b>v</b> akharon <b>o</b> | he terrifies them<br>yevahal <b>emo</b> |
| Psalm 2:5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                     |                                         |

Psalm 2:6 consists of another unmarked speech, this time by Yahweh in response to the kings' speech in 2:1-3. There are seven words separated into two lines. Psalm 2:6a describes Yahweh anointing a king. Psalm 2:6b supplies a prepositional phrase that identifies the location of that anointing, the temple mountain of Zion. The author drops the tight symmetrical design of 2:4-5, creating a climactic sense of finish as Yahweh introduces his king in a countermove to the kings of the land.

## Psalm 2:4-6 As a Whole

The entire sequence of Psalm 2:4-6 displays an inverse symmetry.

- **2:4a** in the skies // **2:6b** on Zion, my holy mountain
- **2:4b** the master // **2:6a** my king
- **2:5a** speak in his anger // **2:5b** in his hot-anger terrify them

## Psalm 2:1-6 As a Whole

The whole of 2:1-6 works as a forward symmetry.

- A and A' — In 2:1, the nations rage and plot empty schemes. In 2:4, the heavenly ruler laughs and mocks.
- B and B' — In 2:2, the kings of the land rebel against Yahweh and his king. In 2:5, God's just anger terrifies them.
- C and C' — In 2:3, we hear a speech from rebel kings, "Resist!" In 2:6, we get a speech from God, "Install the king!"

The two panels are also knit together by an inside-to-outside pattern where features in the middle of one panel match features at the beginning and end of the correlating panel.

## From the Inner to the Outer

### Psalm 2:1-3

- 2:1
- 2:2 Kings and rulers of the earth stand + Yahweh and his anointed
- 2:3

#### Psalm 2:4-6

- 2:4 Heavenly master sits
- 2:5
- 2:6 Earthly king anointed

### From the Outer to the Inner

#### Psalm 2:1-3

- 2:1 Nations rage (= anger)
- 2:2
- 2:3 “bonds/cords of them” (old 3mp pronoun -emo / מו-)

#### Psalm 2:4-6

- 2:4
- 2:5 God's anger + “to them/terrifies them” (old 3mp pronoun -emo / מו-)
- 2:6

# Session 6: Meditating on Psalm 2:7-12

## Key Takeaways

- Psalm 2 presents an ideal portrait of the king in the line of David. In much the same way, Genesis 1 presents an ideal portrait of humanity as the image of God, ruling with wisdom and justice.
- The most useful skill for reading the Bible is noticing the repetition of words and similar ideas.
- The Hebrew Bible portrays various individuals and groups as God's sons. The New Testament authors further develop the portrait by showing how Jesus is the ultimate Son of God, who fulfills the promises of God set down through the ages.

## Psalm 2:7-9

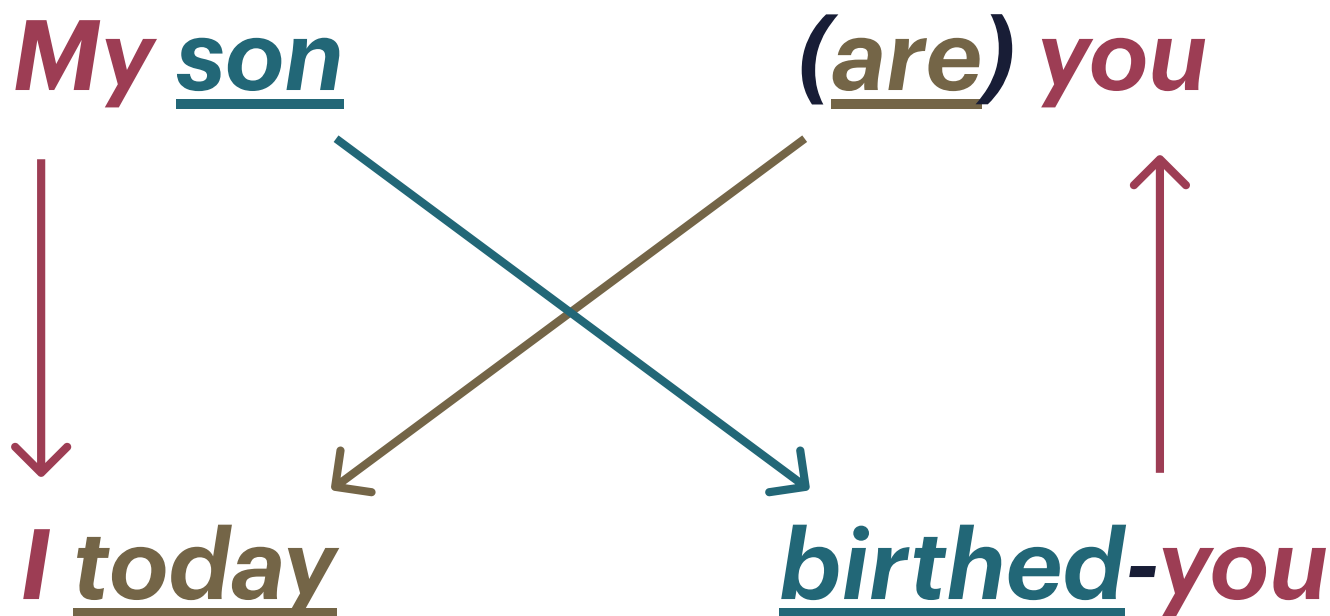
|                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a<br>a'                                                                                                           | 7 "I will surely <b>tell of</b> the decree of Yahweh:<br>He <b>said to</b> me,<br><br>'My <b>Son</b> are <b>you</b><br><b>I</b> , today <b>I-have-birthed</b> - <b>you</b> . | 7 אֲסַפֶּרָה אֶל חֵק יְהוָה<br>אָמַר אֱלֹהִים<br>בְּנֵי אֲתָהּ<br>אֲנִי הַיּוֹם יִלְדֵתִיךָ: |
| a<br>b<br>b'                                                                                                      | 8 Ask of me,<br>and I will give <b>the nations</b> as <b>your</b> inheritance,<br>and <b>your</b> possession <b>the ends of the land</b> .                                   | 8 שְׁאַל מִמֶּנִּי וְאֶתֵּנָה<br>גּוֹיִם נַחֲלָתִיךָ<br>וְאַחֲזִיתֶךָ אֶפְסֵי-אֲרֶץ:         |
| a b<br>b' a'                                                                                                      | 9 <b>You</b> shall break <b>them</b> with a <b>rod</b> of iron,<br>and like a vessel of a potter <b>you</b> shall shatter <b>them</b> .' "                                   | 9 תִּרְעַם בְּשֹׁבֶט בְּרֹזָל<br>כִּכְלִי יוֹצֵר תִּנְפֹּצֵם:                                |
| Psalm 2:7-9. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                              |

Psalm 2:7 consists of two poetic lines. In Psalm 2:7a, the first line is an introduction speech coming from the anointed king, whose installation we read about in 2:1-6. The lines are made up of two parallel parts, so that the king's speech act imitates the sentence structure of God's speech act to him (verb of speech + Hebrew 'el preposition).

|                                                                                                                  | A                                | B                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----------------------|
| 2:7a                                                                                                             | I will surely tell of (ספר + אל) | the decree of Yahweh |
|                                                                                                                  | A'                               |                      |
|                                                                                                                  | he said to me (אמר + אל)         |                      |
| Psalm 2:7a. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |                                  |                      |

In Psalm 2:7b, the second line is the first of a three-part speech from God to the king. It contains a royal presentation formula, using the ancient motif of the king as God's "son." That is, as an earthly representative of the heavenly king.

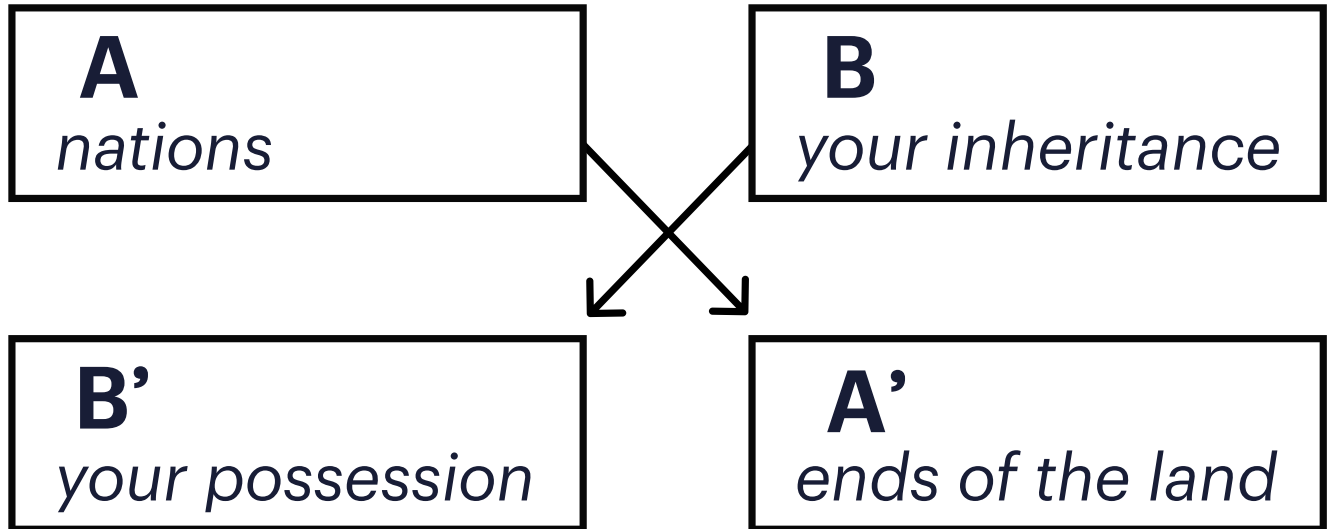
The author designed the pair of lines with a simultaneous inverse symmetry. The pronouns display a forward symmetry: I - you - I - you. The family and time images are an inverse symmetry: son - are - today - birthed.



Psalm 2:7 Inverse Symmetry. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

Psalm 2:8 continues the divine speech with the offer of the family inheritance. The king will now share on earth the possession of kingdoms that belong to God's heavenly ruler over the nations from 2:1-6. This verse displays an inverse symmetry of word order.

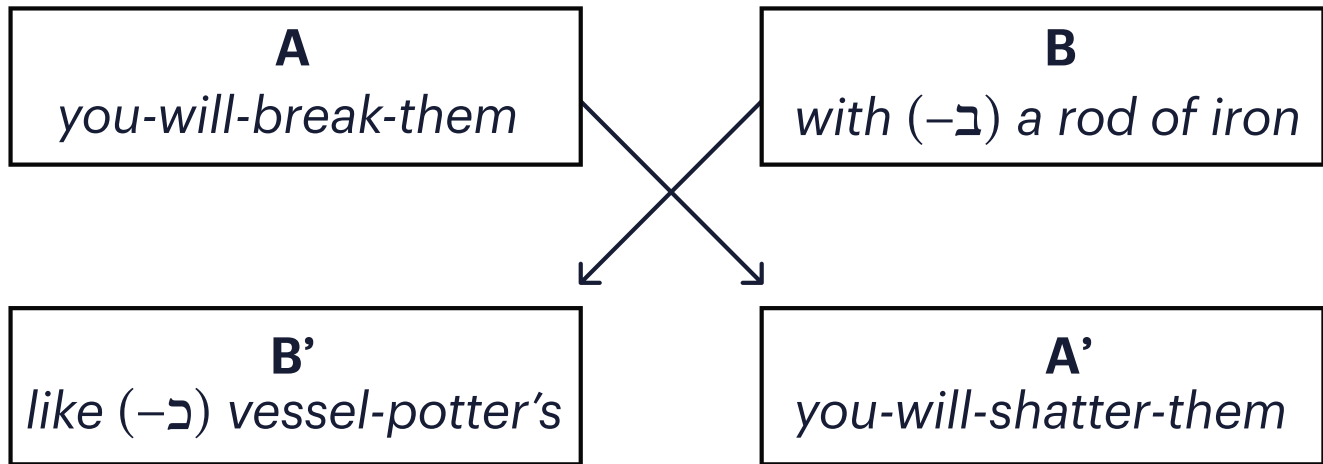
**A    B    C            C'    B'    A'**  
*(you) ask me and I will-give (you)*



*Psalm 2:8 Inverse Symmetry.* Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

Psalm 2:9 concludes the divine speech by bringing up the rebel kings and nations from 2:1-6. We now see why Yahweh laughed at their rebellion in 2:4 and how the king's appointment in 2:6 is a response to them. The king will be the vehicle of Yahweh's judgment on those violent rebel kings. The author arranged the two lines symmetrically.





*Psalm 2:9 Inverse Symmetry. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

Notice how the symmetrical shape draws the images together in an interesting comparison-contrast relationship. When looking at A and A', we see that "breaking" and "shattering" are synonyms. Notice that "shatter" (נִפֵּץ) is used frequently in Jeremiah to describe God's appointed kings as war-clubs to shatter rebel nations like clay jars. See [Jeremiah 22:28](#), [48:12](#), and [51:20-23](#), where Babylon is the war club.

Looking at B and B', we see that these two images are not identical. B indicates the tool used for shattering, whereas B' marks the object shattered by the tool. However, the nearly identical-looking prepositional phrases "like" (כ) and "with" (ב) draw the contrast precisely by their similarity.

## Psalm 2:7-9 as a Whole

There is an important relationship between the king as the son of God in verse 7 and the mention of the "rod" (Hebrew: *shevet* / שֶׁבֶט) in verse 9. This relationship between the son and the rod creates a symmetrical frame around the nations in the center.

- A — 2:7 the king as God's son
- B — 2:8 nations as inheritance
- A' — 2:9 judging with an iron rod

In the Hebrew Bible texts, God appoints David and his royal lineage as the messianic kingship over Israel and the nations. The language of divine sonship and the royal rod-scepter appear in the same context.

### 2 Samuel 7:12-14 NASB

When your days are complete and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your descendant after you, who will come forth from you, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. **I will be a father to him and he will be a son to me;** when he commits iniquity, I will correct him with the **rod** of men and the strokes of the sons of men,

### Psalm 89:20-21, 26-27, 30-32 NASB

I have found **David my servant**; with my holy oil **I have anointed him**, with whom my hand will be established; my arm also will strengthen him.

He will cry to me, '**You are my Father**, my God, and the rock of my salvation.'  
I also shall make him **my firstborn**, the highest of the kings of the earth.

If his sons forsake my law and do not walk in my judgments,  
if they violate my statutes and do not keep my commandments,  
then I will punish their transgression **with the rod** and their iniquity with stripes.

### Isaiah 9:4-6 NASB\*

For you shall break the yoke of their burden and the staff on their shoulders, **the rod** of their oppressor, as at the battle of Midian. For every boot of the booted warrior in the battle tumult, and cloak rolled in blood, will be for burning, fuel for the fire. For **a child will be born to us**, a son will be given to us; and the government will rest on his shoulders; and his name will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Eternal Father, Prince of Peace.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Isaiah 11:1-4 NASB\*

Then **a shoot will spring from the stem of Jesse**, and a branch from his roots will bear fruit. ... But with righteousness he will judge the poor, and decide with fairness for the afflicted of the earth; and he will strike the earth **with the rod** of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he will slay the wicked.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

All of these texts identify the messianic seed from the line of David as God's "son," his royal representative on earth. If he rebels against God's rule, the nations will become God's "rod" to judge the line of David. However, if the nations rebel and the line of David trusts God, they will become God's rod to judge the nations. It cannot be a coincidence, then, that the poet of Psalm 2 chose to place the divine appointment of the king as God's son at the beginning of this speech and then concludes it with mention of the royal rod.

## Psalm 2:7-9 Compared with 2:1-3 and 2:4-6

When we stop and look at the entire poem so far, we can see an important forward symmetrical shape to the three parts. Notice also that the rebel kings' speech in Psalm 2:3 matches the last line of the messianic king's speech in Psalm 2:9.

#### 2:1-3

A - **2:1-2** Longer Narration of the Rebel Kings

B - **2:3** Short Speech: **"Let's break off/shatter their bonds"**

2:4-6

- A' - 2:4-5 Longer Narration of God's Response
- B' - 2:6 Short Speech

2:7-9

- B' - 2:7 Short Narrative of King's Report
- A' - 2:8-9 Longer Speech: “You will break off/shatter them (= the rebel nations)”

Psalm 2:1-9 Speeches. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

Psalm 2:10-12

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a b<br>b' a'            | 10 And now, kings, show discernment;<br>be warned, judges of the land.                                                                                                | 10 וְעַתָּה מְלָכִים הַשְׁכִּילוּ<br>הוֹסְרוּ שִׁפְטֵי אֶרֶץ:                                                          |
| a b<br>a' b'            | 11 Serve Yahweh with fear,<br>and rejoice with trembling.                                                                                                             | 11 עֲבֹדוּ אֶת־יְהוָה בְּיִרְאָה<br>וְגִילוּ בְרַעְדָּה:                                                               |
| a<br>b<br>c<br>b'<br>a' | 12 Kiss the Son,<br>lest he become angry,<br>and you perish in the way,<br>for his anger burns-hot in an instant,<br>How good is life for all who take refuge in him! | 12 נִשְׁקוּ־בֶרֶךְ<br>פֶּן־יִצְאֹנֶה<br>וְתִאבְדּוּ דֶּרֶךְ<br>כִּי־יִבְעַר כְּמַעַט אָפוּ<br>אֲשֶׁר־י כָּל־חֹסֵי בוֹ: |

Psalm 2:10-12. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

Psalm 2:10 has two short poetic lines. Each line has three words shaped in an inverse symmetry.

|       |               |                  |
|-------|---------------|------------------|
|       | A             | B                |
| 2:10a | and-now kings | show discernment |
|       | B'            | A'               |

Psalm 2:10. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

|                                                                                                                         |           |                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------------------|
| 2:10b                                                                                                                   | be-warned | judges of the land |
| <i>Psalm 2:10.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |           |                    |

Psalm 2:11 has two short poetic lines, unbalanced in terms of word count and shaped in forward symmetry. 2:11a consists of four words, but 2:11b has two words.

|                                                                                                                         |              |                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|----------------|
|                                                                                                                         | A            | B              |
| 2:11a                                                                                                                   | serve Yahweh | with fear      |
|                                                                                                                         | A'           | B'             |
| 2:11b                                                                                                                   | and-rejoice  | with trembling |
| <i>Psalm 2:11.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024). |              |                |

The B and B' parts match in a predictable semantic pair. "Fear" and "trembling" are synonyms. The A and A' parts are a surprising and unexpected match, "serve" and "rejoice," though the Psalms regularly call upon God's people as his servants to rejoice and celebrate his generosity and justice ([Ps. 31:7, 16; 89:16, 20](#)).

The jarring connection within "rejoice with trembling" is undoubtedly a riddle, inviting the reader to ponder the dual meaning of God's heavenly rule on earth. Serving Yahweh is a joy for those who fear him, because it leads to life and abundance. However, serving Yahweh is a cause of fear for those who rebel against him, because it will lead to their ruin.

Psalm 2:12 contains the longest set of words and clauses of the entire poem. 2:12a consists of three clauses, each with two Hebrew words. 2:12b consists of two clauses, each with four Hebrew words.

There is evidence of a straightforward overall symmetrical arrangement, however, with the repetition of the word for "anger" (Hebrew: verb אָנַף and noun אַף), and the juxtaposition of negative and positive outcomes based on one's response to the divine son.

**Positive** response to the son

Son's anger

**Negative** consequence

Son's anger

**Positive** consequence

Kiss **the Son**,

lest **he become angry**,

and you perish in the way,

for **his anger burns-hot** in an instant.

How good is life for all who take refuge in him!

*Psalm 2:12. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

## Psalm 2:1-12 as a Whole

<sup>1</sup> Why do **the nations** **rage**,  
and **the peoples** **meditate** on emptiness?

<sup>2</sup> The **kings of the land** take their stand,  
and **the rulers** take counsel together  
against **Yahweh**  
and against **his anointed one**,

<sup>3</sup> "Let us tear apart their bonds,  
and let's cast off from us their cords!"

<sup>4</sup> The one sitting **in the skies**, **he laughs**,  
**my master** **mocks** at them,

<sup>5</sup> then he will speak to them **in his anger**  
and in **his hot-anger** he will terrify them,

<sup>6</sup> "As for me, **I have anointed my King**,  
upon **Zion, my holy mountain**.

<sup>7</sup> I will surely tell of the decree of Yahweh:  
He said to me,  
'You are **my son**,  
today I have birthed you.

<sup>8</sup> Ask of me,  
and I will give **the nations** as your inheritance,  
and **the ends of the land** as your possession.

<sup>9</sup> You shall break them with a rod of iron,  
and like a vessel of a potter, you shall shatter them.’ ”

<sup>10</sup> And now, **kings**, show discernment;  
be warned, O **judges of the land**.

<sup>11</sup> Serve **Yahweh** with fear,  
and rejoice with trembling.

<sup>12</sup> Kiss **the Son**,  
lest **he become angry**,  
and you perish in the way,  
for **his anger burns-hot** in an instant.

How good is life for all who take refuge in him!

*Psalm 2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

When one backs up and looks at the poem as a whole, one can see that the poem has four panels (2:1-3, 2:4-6, 2:7-9, and 2:10-12). Panels 1 and 2 are closely knit together as a paired unit, designed with a forward symmetry, ABCA'B'C'. Panel 3 works as a hinge, picking up the theme of both the rebel kings and the anointed king. Panel 4 picks up the main ideas of panels 1-2 and 3 and combines all the elements. Notice how panel 4 brings together into one panel many words and ideas that are split apart in panels 1-2 and 3.

- Panels 1-2: **nations, kings of the land, rulers** + **Yahweh and anointed king**
- Panel 3: **nations, ends of the land** + **my son**
- Panel 4: **kings, judges of the land** + **Yahweh and the son**

## Poet Describes Rebel Kings

### The Nations Rage

A <sup>1</sup> Why do **the nations** **rage**,  
and **the peoples** **meditate** on emptiness?

### They Rebel Against Yahweh

<sup>2</sup> The **kings of the land** take their stand,  
B and **the rulers** take counsel together  
against **Yahweh**  
and against **his anointed one**,

### Their Rebellious Speech

- C' <sup>3</sup> "Let us tear apart their bonds,  
and let's cast off from us their cords!"

---

## Yahweh's Response

---

### Yahweh Laughs

---

- A' <sup>4</sup> The one sitting **in the skies**, **he laughs**,  
**my master** **mocks** at them,

### He Responds in Anger

---

- B' <sup>5</sup> then he will speak to them **in his anger**  
and in **his hot-anger** he will terrify them,

### Yahweh's Counter-speech

---

- C' <sup>6</sup> "As for me, **I have anointed my King**,  
upon **Zion, my holy mountain**.

---

## The Anointed King Tells of Yahweh's Decree

---

### Divine Sonship

---

- <sup>7</sup> I will surely tell of the decree of Yahweh:  
He said to me,  
'You are **my son**,  
today I have birthed you.

### Kingdom Over All Nations

---

- <sup>8</sup> Ask of me,  
and I will give **the nations** as your inheritance,  
and **the ends of the land** as your possession.

### Victory Over Enemies

---

- <sup>9</sup> You shall break them with a rod of iron,  
and like a vessel of a potter, you shall shatter them.' "

### Poet Warns the Rebellious Kings

---

- <sup>10</sup> And now, **kings**, show discernment;  
be warned, O **judges of the land**.  
<sup>11</sup> Serve **Yahweh** with fear,

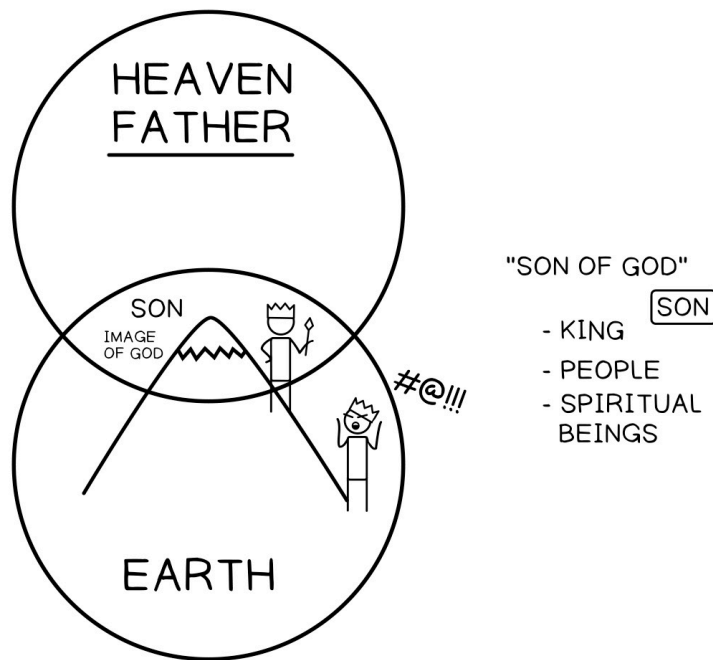
and rejoice with trembling.

<sup>12</sup> Kiss **the Son**,  
lest **he become angry**,  
and you perish in the way,  
for **his anger burns-hot** in an instant,  
How good is life for all who **take refuge** in him!

*Psalm 2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

This poem is a meditation on the appointment of the Davidic messiah as Yahweh's son who will deal with the violence of rebellious nations. God's "decree" (קח) reflects elements of God's promise to David in 2 Samuel 7, combined with God's promise to Abraham. God promised a divinely appointed king who rules on Mount Zion (2 Sam. 7:11b-12, 16), victory over enemy nations (2 Sam. 7:10b-11a), and possession of the nations (Gen. 22:17-18).

## The Son of God in Psalm 2



*The Son of God in Psalm 2. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*



# Session 7: Meditating on Psalms 1 and 2 Together

## Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors are deeply interested in the relationship between the one and the many. The path of an individual's life is analogous to the path of a whole community.
- Psalms 1 and 2 coordinate to draw two major themes about the ideal human, the wise Torah meditator and the chosen king, and focus them into a sharper outline of a promised messianic king.
- In Mark 1:11, God announces Jesus' identity in language lifted directly from Psalm 2:7 and other texts from the Hebrew Bible (Gen. 22:2 and Isa. 42:1).
- The parallels between these two psalms direct us to identify the good-life man of Psalm 1 with the messianic king of Psalm 2. The good-life man is a model for us to follow as we find our refuge in the Messiah.

## Psalms 1 and 2 Compared

| Psalm 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Psalm 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>How good is life</b> for the man who doesn't walk by the counsel of <b>the wicked</b>, and in the path of <b>sinners</b> he does not <b>stand</b>, and in <b>the seat</b> of <b>mockers</b> he does not <b>sit</b>.</p> <p><sup>2</sup> Rather, in the <b>instruction of Yahweh</b> is his <b>delight</b> and on his <b>instruction</b> he <b>meditates</b> day and night.</p> | <p><sup>1</sup> Why do <b>the nations</b> rage, and <b>the peoples</b> <b>meditate</b> on empty matters?</p> <p><sup>2</sup> <b>The kings</b> of the land take their <b>stand</b>, and <b>the rulers</b> take counsel together against Yahweh and against his anointed one,</p> <p><sup>3</sup> "Let us tear apart their bonds, and let's cast off from us their cords!"</p> <p><sup>4</sup> The one <b>sitting</b> in the skies, he laughs, my master mocks at them,</p> <p><sup>5</sup> then he will speak to them in <b>his anger</b> and in his <b>hot-anger</b> he will terrify them.</p> <p><sup>6</sup> "As for me, I have anointed my King, upon <b>Zion, my holy mountain</b>."</p> |
| <p><i>Psalms 1 and 2 Compared.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

| Psalm 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Psalm 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><sup>3</sup> And he will become like a tree planted by streams of water,<br/> which gives <b>its fruit</b> in its time,<br/> and <b>its leaf</b> does not wither,<br/> and everything he will do, he makes <b>successful</b>.</p> <p><sup>4</sup> Not so the wicked;<br/> rather, he is <b>like chaff</b> that the wind drives away,</p> | <p><sup>7</sup> “I will surely tell of the decree of Yahweh:<br/> He said to me,<br/> ‘You are <b>my Son</b>,<br/> today <b>I have birthed you</b>.<br/> <sup>8</sup> Ask of me,<br/> and I will give the nations as your <b>inheritance</b>,<br/> and the ends of the land as your <b>possession</b>.<br/> <sup>9</sup> You shall break them with a rod of iron,<br/> and <b>like a vessel of a potter</b>, you shall shatter them.’ ”</p> |
| <p><sup>5</sup> Therefore, <b>the wicked</b> will not stand in the judgment,<br/> nor <b>sinner</b>s in the assembly of the righteous,</p> <p><sup>6</sup> because Yahweh knows <b>the path</b> of the righteous,<br/> but <b>the path</b> of <b>the wicked will perish</b>.</p>                                                            | <p><sup>10</sup> And now, <b>kings</b>, show discernment;<br/> be warned, O <b>judges</b> of the land.<br/> <sup>11</sup> Serve Yahweh with fear,<br/> and rejoice with trembling.<br/> <sup>12</sup> Kiss the Son,<br/> lest he become angry,<br/> and you <b>perish in the path</b>,<br/> for his anger burns-hot in an instant.<br/> <b>How good is life</b> for all who take refuge in him!</p>                                         |
| <p><i>Psalms 1 and 2 Compared.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

There are very prominent links at the beginning and ending of the poems, which invite the reader to meditate on other, less obvious connections.

## Repetition of Identical Words or Synonyms

In Psalm 1:1, the three-part list of the “bad guys” (wicked, sinner, mocker) is parallel to Psalm 2:1-2 and its four-part list of the “bad guys” (nations, peoples, kings, rulers).

“Seat/sit” (Hebrew: יושב/מושב) and “stand” (עמד) in Psalm 1:1 are parallel to “stand” (יצב) in Psalm 2:2 and “the one sitting” (יושב) in Psalm 2:4. In Psalm 1:2, “meditate” (יהגה) is parallel to “meditate” (יהגו) in Psalm 2:1. “The path ... will perish” (דֶּרֶךְ ... תֵּאבֵד) in Psalm 1:6 matches “perish in the path” (תֵּאבְדוּ דֶּרֶךְ) from Psalm 2:12.

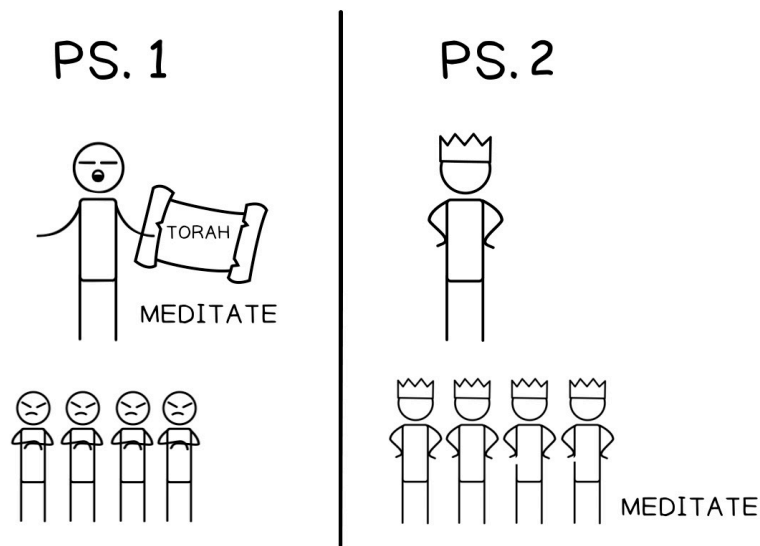
## Connections Between Associated Words and Ideas

In Psalm 1:2, “instruction” (Hebrew: *torah* / תורה) connects to Psalm 2:6, “Zion, my holy mountain,” often associated with the source of God’s instruction found in the temple (see [Isa. 2:1-4](#)). “Leaf” and “fruit” in

Psalm 1:3 connect to “children” and “birth” in Psalm 2:7 (see days three and six of [Gen. 1](#)). In Psalm 1:3, “success” connects to “inheritance” and “possession” from Psalm 2:8. “Chaff” in Psalm 1:4 connects to “vessel of a potter” in Psalm 2:9.

Most prominent of all is the identical keyword (אשרי) in the first line of Psalm 1 and the last line of Psalm 2, “How good is life ...”

## Comparing Figures of Psalms 1 and 2



*Comparing Figures of Psalms 1 and 2.* Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).

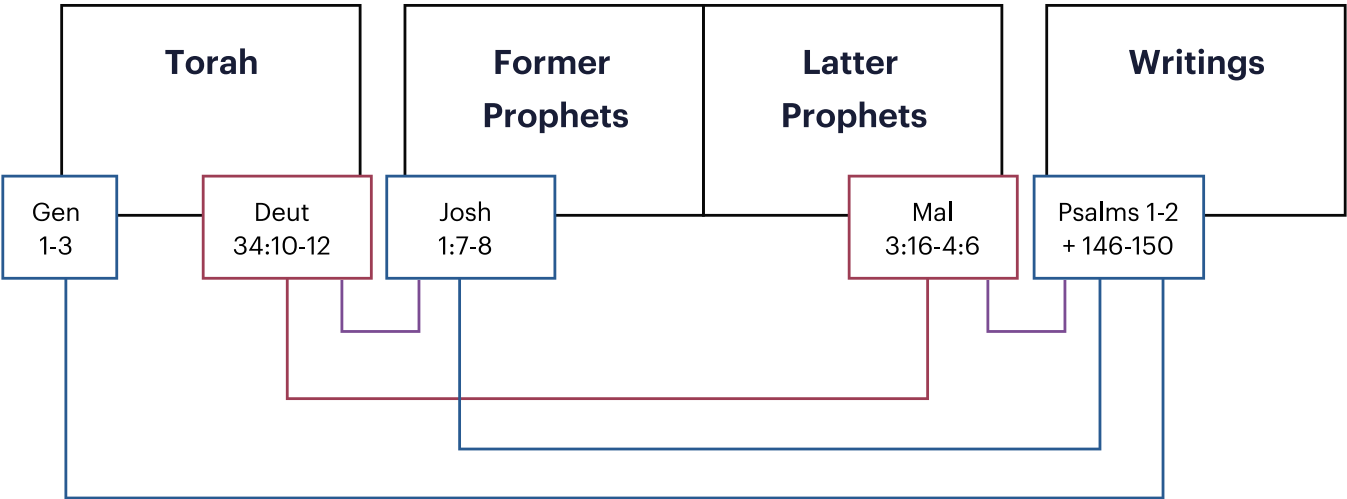
# Session 8: Psalms 1 and 2 and the Seams of the TaNaKh

## Key Takeaways

- Psalms 1 and 2 serve as the introduction to the Psalms scroll and to the whole Ketuvim (Writings). Both the beginning and the end (Ps. 146-150) of the Psalms scroll repeat themes from Genesis 1-3.
- Repeated words and phrases coordinate Psalm 1 and Joshua 1, linking the beginning of the Prophets to the beginning of the Writings. The connections at the highest level of whole collections are tied together using the same techniques that connect ideas within the same sentence or passage.
- The structural artistry of the biblical text actively invites meditation and teaches us how to think about God and ourselves.

## The Psalms Scroll and the Editorial Design of the TaNaKh

The three-part shape of the Hebrew Bible is not simply a matter of arrangement. Rather, the authors designed the books themselves to fit into this particular shape. If you examine the editorial seams of the major sections (remember, the book technology was typically papyrus or leather scrolls), you will find intentional design clues at the beginning and ending of these sections.



*TaNaK Editorial Design, v. 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Reading the Bible as Meditation Literature (2024).*

## Seam 1

The final sentences of the Torah and the opening sentences of the Prophets are knit together by common words and narrative themes. [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#) is about the anticipation of a coming Moses-like prophet who was promised but never came. [Joshua 1:1-9](#) is about God's appointed leader, Joshua, who will lead the people into the promised land and must meditate on the Torah day and night to find success.

## Seam 2

The final sentences of the Prophets engage the opening sentences of the Ketuvim. [Malachi 3:16-4:6](#) tells how God's servants listen to the "scroll of remembrance." They anticipate a coming judgment and separation of the righteous from the wicked, linked to the coming of an Elijah-like prophet. This prophet will call the people back to the Torah and restore the hearts of Israel before the Day of the Lord. In Psalm 1, the righteous one vindicated in the final judgment is the one who meditates on the Torah day and night to find success. In Psalm 2, this righteous one is the future messianic king from the line of David, whom God appoints to rule the nations and overcome evil once and for all.

## Seam 3

The Psalms scroll's opening unit (Ps. 1-2) and closing unit (Ps. 146-150) are rich with hyperlinks back to Genesis 1-2. In [Psalm 1:3](#), the Torah-meditator is like a tree planted by streams of water. This idea connects to [Genesis 2:16-17](#) and God's wise command regarding the trees of the garden and the tree of life. The two "paths" (Hebrew: דרך) of the righteous and wicked lead to life or to ruin in [Psalm 1:1](#) and [Psalm 1:5](#). The path (דרך) into and out of Eden leads to life or death in [Genesis 3:23-24](#).

In [Psalm 2:7-9](#), the God-appointed king of David is God's Son, who will rule and subdue the rebel nations. We see a parallel in [Genesis 1:26-28](#), where humanity is God's image, meant to rule and subdue the wild animals. There is also a hyperlink to [Genesis 1:1](#) when "in the beginning" (בראשית) God created the skies and the land. The word "beginning" (*re'shit*) is the same as the word for "firstfruits," which can be firstfruits of land, animals, or humans (see [Gen. 49:3](#); [Deut. 21:17](#); [Ps. 78:51](#), [105:36](#)).

The rebel kings are to show "discernment" (השכיל) in [Psalm 2:10](#) by responding humbly to the Son of God's rule over them. In [Genesis 3:6-7](#), the humans see that the forbidden tree is good for gaining wisdom (השכיל), and they rebel against God's command.

[Psalm 146:5-6](#) reads "How good is life (אשרי) for those who have the God of Jacob as their delivering-ally (עוזר) ... maker of skies and land and the sea and everything in them." This passage echoes [Genesis 2:1](#), "And thus were finished the skies and the land and everything in them," as well as [Genesis 2:18-25](#), where God provides woman as the "delivering-ally" (עוזר) for the human.

Psalm 148 is a creation poem that systematically works through the list of created things in Genesis 1:1-2:3, calling them to "praise Yahweh." [Psalm 150:1](#) sings "praise him in the strong sky-dome (רקיע)." God makes the "sky-dome" (רקיע) on day two ([Gen. 1:6-8](#)). In [Genesis 2:7](#), Yahweh breathes the "breath-of-life" (נשמה) into the human of clay. [Psalm 150:6](#) tells us to "let all that has breath-of-life (נשמה) praise Yahweh."

## Conclusion

The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature designed to foster a lifetime practice of reading and pondering the meaning of these texts. It points to future hope in the promised prophet who will herald the arrival of the Day of the Lord and the messianic kingdom (Deut. 34, Mal. 4). It encourages us to meditate on a covenantal way of life that creates a counterculture to the prevailing world systems (Josh. 1, Ps. 1).

Who is capable of comprehending the extent of what is to be discovered in a single utterance of Yours? For we leave behind in it far more than we take from it, like thirsty people drinking from a fountain. ... Anyone who encounters Scripture should not suppose that the single one of its riches that he has found is the only one to exist; rather, he should realize that he himself is only capable of discovering that one out of the many riches which exist in it. Nor, because Scripture has enriched him, should the reader impoverish it. ... Let the fountain vanquish your thirst, your thirst should not vanquish the fountain! ... Give thanks for what you have taken away, and do not complain about the superfluity that is left over.

Brock, Sebastian (1992). *The Luminous Eye: The Spiritual Vision of Saint Ephrem the Syrian*. Citing Ephrem the Syrian, *Commentary on the Diatessaron* 1.18–19. 50–51.

# Session 9: Reflecting on Biblical Meditation

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## Key Takeaways

- Far from cold academic analysis, learning to appreciate the craftsmanship and literary design of the Bible can lead to deeper faith and refreshed devotion.
- Because the biblical text is deeply interconnected, meditation on a single passage can surface reflections on the whole of the biblical story.
- Paying attention to the way later biblical authors make connections in the text can help us verify the connections we find or lead us to notice things we missed.
- Discerning the underlying structure and noticing repeated words can support memorization of large sections of the Bible.



**This session has no notes**